

WC 2026 Youth Training Report

Where did World Cup 2026 starting-lineup players train between ages 5 and 16?

Data through 75 completed matches · July 5, 2026

Completed matches	Unique starters	Unique training countries	Unique training clubs
75	754	53	975

Top 20 Training Countries

Unique starters counts each player once for every country where they trained, regardless of how long they spent there.

Weighted starters allocates each player as a fraction across countries in proportion to the years they spent training there between ages 5 and 16 — for example, a player who trained 8 years in France and 4 years in Spain contributes 0.67 to France and 0.33 to Spain. See Appendix 1 for the full counting rule.

#	Country	Unique starters	Weighted starters
1	France	70	59.48
2	England	49	36.51
3	Netherlands	47	39.27
4	Spain	38	27.93
5	Germany	38	27.63
6	United States	31	21.59
7	Belgium	28	22.78
8	Argentina	26	20.33
9	Portugal	23	16.80
10	Norway	22	17.16
11	Sweden	21	15.73
12	Austria	19	17.08
13	Switzerland	17	15.90
14	Japan	17	15.35
15	Brazil	17	15.17
16	Australia	17	13.13
17	Paraguay	17	10.28
18	Uzbekistan	17	6.00
19	Czechia	16	12.50
20	Canada	16	12.29

Top 20 Training Clubs

Same year-share method as above, applied at club level. Players who moved between clubs are split across each club in proportion to time spent there.

#	Club	Country	Unique starters	Weighted starters
1	Anderlecht	Belgium	10	6.11
2	Paris Saint-Germain	France	10	4.53
3	Barcelona	Spain	10	4.24
4	Ajax	Netherlands	9	5.59
5	PSV	Netherlands	8	4.90
6	Independiente del Valle	Ecuador	8	4.07
7	Manchester City	England	8	3.84
8	Bayern Munich	Germany	7	3.81
9	Dinamo Zagreb	Croatia	7	3.71
10	Benfica	Portugal	7	3.37
11	Genk	Belgium	7	1.68
12	Fulham	England	6	3.97
13	Chelsea	England	6	3.49
14	Rennes	France	6	3.46
15	Lyon	France	6	3.09
16	Cerro Porteño	Paraguay	6	2.55
17	Al Ahly	Egypt	5	4.00
18	Manchester United	England	5	3.13
19	Hajduk Split	Croatia	5	2.98
20	Red Bull Salzburg	Austria	5	2.73

Local-Trained Ratio by National Team

Percentage of each team's tracked starters who spent more than 5 years training in their own country between ages 5 and 16. Sorted from highest to lowest. Players without year data are excluded from this count.

National team	Tracked starters	Locally trained	Local ratio
Portugal	14	14	100%
England	17	16	94%
France	15	13	87%
Germany	13	11	85%
Netherlands	13	11	85%
Spain	16	13	81%
Switzerland	16	13	81%
Austria	15	12	80%
Belgium	17	12	71%
Sweden	14	10	71%
Japan	17	11	65%
Brazil	14	8	57%
Czechia	18	10	56%
Scotland	16	9	56%
Argentina	21	11	52%
Croatia	16	8	50%
Türkiye	18	9	50%
Canada	17	8	47%
Egypt	15	7	47%
Ecuador	13	6	46%
Norway	21	8	38%
Australia	17	5	29%
Saudi Arabia	15	4	27%
Paraguay	16	4	25%
Senegal	16	4	25%
Tunisia	16	4	25%
New Zealand	13	3	23%
Colombia	14	3	21%
IR Iran	15	3	20%

Panama	15	3	20%
Qatar	15	3	20%
Bosnia and Herzegovina	16	3	19%
Ghana	16	3	19%
Uzbekistan	17	3	18%
Cabo Verde	18	3	17%
Uruguay	13	2	15%
Haiti	14	2	14%
USA	21	3	14%
Morocco	15	2	13%
Mexico	17	2	12%
Côte d'Ivoire	15	1	7%
DR Congo	14	1	7%
Jordan	14	1	7%
Korea Republic	14	1	7%
Iraq	16	1	6%
South Africa	16	1	6%
Algeria	16	0	0%
Curaçao	13	0	0%

Appendix 1 — Data Conditions and Counting Rules

Data sources

- **Starting XIs:** Wikipedia 2026 FIFA World Cup group and knockout-stage pages, scraped via BeautifulSoup. Each starting-XI row is linked to its match section URL.
- **Youth-club histories:** Wikipedia player infobox 'Youth career' section, fetched per player. Year spans and club names are parsed directly from the infobox table.
- **Club countries:** Inferred from each linked club's Wikipedia page lead text and categories using phrase-pattern matching.

Age window

Only training that overlaps the age range 5–16 is included. If a Wikipedia source gives a spell of 2008–2015 for a player born in 2000, that is converted to ages 8–15 and clipped to the 5–16 window.

Counting rule for players who moved

Each player's contribution is split across clubs and countries in proportion to the number of years they spent at each during ages 5–16. For example, a player who trained 8 years in France and 4 years in Spain contributes 0.67 to France and 0.33 to Spain. Where no year data is available, an equal split across clubs is used as a fallback.

Confidence tiers

- **Medium:** year span extracted from Wikipedia infobox; age estimates calculated from the player's birth year.
- **Low (fallback):** only a club name was available with no year span. The club is counted in unique starters but contributes 0 to weighted starters.
- **Unresolved:** 52 players have no usable youth section on Wikipedia. They are excluded from all rankings.

Known limitations

- The tournament was still in progress on the data collection date (2026-07-05). Knockout matches from the Round of 16 onwards are partially included.
- Club-country assignment is automated and may misclassify youth academies with ambiguous Wikipedia pages.
- Multi-country starters (102) are split across countries; multi-club starters (353) are split across clubs.
- Country backfill covers 1385 of 1385 youth-club rows. Rows without a country are excluded from country rankings only.

Source data

The underlying CSV files used to produce this report are publicly available at:
github.com/lorihe/WC2026-youth-clubs/tree/main/data